

HISD Press Release

72 HISD students named National Merit semifinalists

*Students will have opportunity to compete for more than \$32 million in
scholarships*

Sept. 29, 2017 – Seventy-two seniors from six Houston Independent School District high schools have qualified as semifinalists in the 63rd annual National Merit Scholarship Program, earning one of the top academic honors in the nation. HISD had 51 semifinalists last year.

The students are among 16,000 from across the country to earn the semifinalist designation, allowing them the opportunity to continue in the academic competition and vie for more than \$32 million in scholarships that will be awarded in the spring.

The students attend Bellaire, Carnegie Vanguard, Lamar, and Westside high schools, as well as DeBakey High School for Health Professions and the High School for Performing and Visual Arts.

“Being recognized by the National Merit Scholarship Program is one of the highest academic honors that our students can receive,” HISD Superintendent Richard Carranza said. “I am so proud to see so many of our students on this list. It just goes to show we’re producing true Global Graduates.”

The National Merit Scholarship Program provides college scholarships to academically talented U.S. high school students who score well on the Preliminary SAT. Scholarships are provided to students from each state who have the strongest combination of accomplishments, skills, and potential for college success.

About 1.6 million juniors from more than 22,000 high schools across the country took the 2016 Preliminary SAT, which serves as the National Merit Scholarship Qualifying Test. Fewer than one percent — or about 16,000 students — were named as semifinalists.

About 15,000 students are expected to advance to the finalist level in February. About half of the finalists are expected to go on to earn a National Merit Scholarship and the official National Merit Scholar designation.

National Merit Scholars are chosen based on their skills, accomplishments, and potential for success in college.

Bellaire High School

Robert A. Brown

Rachel M. Contello

[Eric J. Dai](#)
[Daniel P. Entchev](#)
[Evan Y. Han](#)
[Alexander J. Ho](#)
[Jasmine L. Huant](#)
[Wendy Jin](#)
[Patrick M. Kelly](#)
[Tirtha M. Kharel](#)
[Christopher I. Levitt](#)
[Michelle M. Lin](#)
[Ruth Ling](#)
[Sara E. Macia](#)
[Skylar N. McAuliffe](#)
[Alexander K. Nguyen](#)
[Gabrielle D. Olinger](#)
[Emily Y. Pan](#)
[Charlotte M. Parsons](#)
[Mackenzie L. Parsons](#)
[Rebecca C. Parsons](#)
[Emily P. Richards](#)
[Pavan A. Shukla](#)
[Kabir Sood](#)
[Samantha L. Su](#)
[Elizabeth R. Szafranski](#)
[Jacob M. Tate](#)
[Omar Uraimov](#)
[Sarah J. Wen](#)
[Scott S. Williams](#)
[Jingyi Xin](#)
[Anna C. Xu](#)
[Jennifer Xu](#)
[Yuanchen Yuan](#)
[Julia J. Zheng](#)
[Geoffrey W. Zimmerman](#)
[Carnegie Vanguard High School](#)
[Cassandra L. Bailey](#)
[Kartik Devashish](#)
[Amanda H. Feldman](#)
[Garrett M. Holmes](#)
[Caitlin Hsu](#)
[Anuj K. Jajoo](#)
[Raymond J. Jessup](#)

[Hee Soo Jung](#)

[Rukmini Kalamangalam](#)

[Matthew J. Karam](#)

[Riordan K. Keneally](#)

[Griffin R. Khosla](#)

[Samuel W. Liu](#)

[An K. Nguyen](#)

[Ifeoluwani E. Omidiran](#)

[Katherine F. Powers](#)

[Keshav S. Srivaths](#)

[DeBakey High School for Health Professions](#)

[Sidharth N. Belaguli](#)

[Elif Naz Kilicarslan](#)

[Aishwarya S. Kotha](#)

[William T. Mo](#)

[Vijay Nitturi](#)

[Eric Ou](#)

[Jacqueline D. Pham](#)

[Vera M. Schroeder](#)

[Brian Xue](#)

[Mason A. Yeh](#)

[Larry W. Zhang](#)

[High School for the Performing and Visual Arts](#)

[Trevor Z. Fu](#)

[Tuesday B. Haynes](#)

[Jonathan J. Jalbert](#)

[Caroline E. O'Connor](#)

[Lamar High School](#)

[Camile R. Calabrese](#)

[Jiayuan Han](#)

[Westside High School](#)

[Hsin-Wei "Derek" Chen](#)

[Sarah G. Hudson](#)

MONROE TOWNSHIP SCHOOL DISTRICT | ADVOCACY
MIDDLESEX COUNTY, NJ



Dear <TARGET>:

My name is [Insert Name](#) and I am a resident of Monroe Township, New Jersey in Middlesex County. I kindly request that you support the immediate design and implementation of a new School Funding Formula (SFF), which will more equitably distribute school aid to all New Jersey School districts, including the Monroe Township School District (MTSD).

Earlier in 2022, a proposal (A3578, S354) was made to legislators for the establishment of a school funding task force (A3578, S354). The envisioned purpose of this task force was to review and redesign the school funding formula to provide all school districts with a fair and equitable allocation of aid. Regrettably, no movement has been made on this legislation in over a year. As a result, our students, staff members, and community continue to be negatively affected by this unfair formula.

Listed below are some explicit flaws in the current SFF:

- ← The SFF has not been updated or revised in over 15 years and is not driven by current demographic evolutions/reports
- ← The MTSD currently receives no (\$0.00) equalization aid from the state
- ← The MTSD currently receives <\$1,000 per student
- ← Approximately 50% of the residents in Monroe Township live on fixed incomes

In Spring 2023, the Monroe Township School District was notified that Budget Resolution #924 “Appropriating \$1 million to the Monroe Township School District for infrastructure improvements at the Applegarth Elementary School” was included in the final budget signed by Governor Murphy.

While our district is very grateful to have the allotted \$1 million appropriated to address some of the infrastructure needs of our district, this amount falls far below the amount needed to meet the operational and curricular needs of our rapidly expanding and diverse learning community. The scope of our district’s needs expands beyond a singular school building and has been magnified by the rapid growth and development of the Monroe Township Learning Community. Currently, our district’s emergent infrastructure needs include, but are not limited to:

- ← **Applegarth Elementary School** | ADA Toilet Room Renovations
- ← **Monroe Township Middle School** | HVAC Systems (Replacement & Upgrade)
- ← **Monroe Township Middle School** | Boiler Replacement
- ← **Monroe Township Middle School** | ADA Toilet Room Renovations
- ← **Monroe Township Middle School** | Partial Window Replacement
- ← **Monroe Township High School** | Stadium Bleachers, Storage, & Team Rooms

The minimal allotment of annual state aid we receive has significantly crippled the MTSD’s ability to manage our emergent facility needs within our operating budget. It is unfair to continue placing this heavy financial burden on taxpayers, who are already paying for ~85% of the district’s operational cost. Therefore, I ask you to pass the school funding task force legislation and prioritize creating an equitable school funding formula. The Monroe Township School District is always willing to discuss our continued need for additional school funding with officials, including those from the NJDOE and local governments. We hope you would be willing to meet with stakeholders from the MTSD and leaders from our local Board of Education, to speak about our unique financial needs, and operational constraints resulting from the lack of adequate state funding.

Thank you in advance for your efforts to support the Monroe Township School District.

Sincerely,

